



AFP PHOTO/PAUL CROCK



INDIA EXPECTS:
(Clockwise from left)
Narang, Bindra and
Athens medallist
Rathore



VIKRAM SHARMA

THE EVENTS

10M AIR RIFLE: Shots are fired from a standing position into the bull's eye 0.55mm wide
 🇮🇳 Abhinav Bindra, Gagan Narang, Anjali Bhagwat and Avneet Kaur

50M RIFLE 3 POSITION: In this event, the shooter is required to fire in the prone, standing and kneeling positions at a target 50m away
 🇮🇳 Narang, Bhagwat, Sanjeev Rajput

10M AIR PISTOL: Shots are taken in the standing position at 11.5mm (half inch) target at a distance of 10 metres
 🇮🇳 Samaresh Jung

TRAP: Targets are fired out of a bunker up to a distance of 75m and at speeds of 80 mph
 🇮🇳 Manavjit Singh Sandhu

DOUBLE TRAP: Two targets are launched at different heights and angles. The shooters get one shot each at the targets.
 🇮🇳 Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore

🇮🇳 Indian contenders in Beijing

hear are clicks. The trap shooters stand with heads bowed like condemned men until it's their turn and then call. The targets fly free, dart about, the shooter's shoulders twitch, the gun barks and then there's silence again. Until the next man steps up.

It's only when the scores are tallied that the awful, uneven equation is made clear: in the biggest event in the world, four years of work are distilled into an hour that ends, for most competitors, in tears. After a nightmare in her Athens preliminaries, Anjali Bhagwat sat in the gallery with her husband trying to get her hands to stop shaking. She gave up shooting for more than a year before returning.

Let's not go there, says Mansher Singh. "We need to try to get as many shooters into the finals as we can." In Athens, three out of eight shooters (Bindra, Rathore and air riflewoman

WITHOUT THE **TEMPESTUOUS** HOCKEY TEAM TO ACT AS A BUFFER AGAINST EXPECTATION, INDIA'S SHOOTERS WILL FEEL A **BILLION** ON THEIR NECKS.